

**ANIL THADANI**FOUNDER,
AA FILMS

“KGF was a small Kannada film... We made people realise the importance of the film, they got attracted to the trailer and they walked into the cinemas to watch it”

**JAYANTILAL GADA**CHAIRMAN & MD,
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“Five out of the 200 south films worked pan-India. Bollywood should have released 70 films, but 20 were released [in theatres] as the rest went to OTTs”

but would not have taken that much of a risk unless we heard it from the horse's mouth,” says Kiragandur.

Rajamouli helped bring Thadani on board, who in turn brought in Excel Entertainment also to distribute the film. But it clashed with Shah Rukh Khan-starrer *Zero* at the box office and ended up with fewer screens in the north. *KGF1*, released in December 2018, was a huge success in Kannada and collected around ₹45 crore net in Hindi. *KGF2*, released in April 2022, made nearly 10 times as much in Hindi and grossed ₹1,200 crore worldwide. The success was intentional, and quite scientific.

Hombale Films, part of the Hombale Group, put the pandemic break between the two parts to good use and commissioned BookMyShow to conduct field surveys in 55 cities to check awareness about the film. “Ninety-eight per cent of the people knew about *KGF*. Out of that, 95 per cent wanted to see *KGF2*,” says Kiragandur. TV and streaming had carried it to the audiences of other languages. An analysis of the YouTube views for the teaser, which has garnered 270 million views so far, showed significant interest for the film in Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Rajasthan, and Gujarat, and in the international markets of Malaysia, Singapore, the US and Canada. When they

released the film in more screens in those pockets, they found that box office collections mirrored the YouTube analytics and survey data. “Though it is a Kannada movie, we got more interest from TN. The BO result was also the same and we never expected it.” Big film or small, Kiragandur says, they always get a survey done pre-shoot and one pre-release. “You cannot give whatever you like to the audience and make them watch it. First, you have to understand their behaviour, mindset and taste.”

Unlike the other films whose national success came about intentionally, Allu Arjun-starrer *Pushpa* was different. Again, it was Rajamouli who encouraged the makers to consider Hindi markets. But left with hardly any time for marketing, the makers relied entirely on TV promotions and Thadani's distribution might to carry the film. “We were clear that with our budgets, we would be able to recover the money in our core markets. Hindi was just a trial and error,” says Mythri Movie Makers Co-founder Y. Ravi Shankar. But the tale of *Pushpa Raj*, a coolie with a stumble mouthing the catchphrase *Thaggede Le/Main Jhukega Nahi* (I will not bow down), and his rise among the red sandalwood mafia, caught the imagination of the masses, spawning countless Instagram Reels and memes. “We were definitely surprised by the success outside south India. We never thought it will be so massive because we didn't give much time for promotions,” says Shankar.

Regretting not promoting *Pushpa* and their previous venture *Rangasthalam* starring Ram Charan, in the North, he talks of a Nepal-based distributor who, pre-release, was willing to pay any price for a print of the film. Still amazed by the breadth of the film's success, an exuberant Shankar says: “While travelling from Turkey, I met a film-maker from Pakistan's Multan. He said, ‘Sir, *Pushpa*, what a song, sir!’” Armed with hindsight, the makers plan to release the sequel in 10 languages and several neighbouring countries by August 2023, but only after vigorously promoting the film in every possible part of India for two months. Shankar sees the promotion budget jump almost 5x to ₹50 crore this time.



BUT THE CREDIT doesn't belong to the film-makers and producers from the South alone. It's a trend in the making for almost 25 years now. Ironically, some trace it back to the super-hit Hindi movie *Dil Chahta Hai* (2001). Farhan Akhtar's directorial debut about the coming-of-